



No mercy: Iga Swiatek overpowered the merely human Jasmine Paolini for a predictable 6-2, 6-1 triumph.

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SWIATEK STREAKS TO FOURTH TITLE AS ALCARAZ WINS HIS FIRST

Paul Fein

Casual tennis fans may not have even heard of the late-blooming 28-year-old Jasmine Paolini, who had never made it past the second round of a Major until this year, when the Italian reached the fourth round of the Australian Open.

She then showed it was no fluke by winning a WTA 1000 title in Dubai. Her breakthrough year peaked in Paris where she outlasted 2022 Wimbledon champion Elena Rybakina in the quarterfinals and outclassed fast-rising 17-year-old Mirra Andreieva to meet Iga Swiatek in the final.

Although small in stature at 5'4", Paolini is big in the intangibles:

competitiveness, poise, and more recently, confidence. Unlike some players who have exuded a priori confidence like Jimmy Connors and Serena Williams before they achieved great results, Jasmine was bogged down by an inferiority complex since turning pro in 2011. It took career-changing success this season to change her mentality. After taking out Rybakina, she